The Memory Cycle Journal

LEAD STORY · KEY NUMBERS · FROM THE INBOX · ON X · CYCLE TRACKER · EVENTS

KOREA CHIP EXPORTS (OCTOBER)
$56.44B +259.4% y/y · second month above $50B · total exports $115.28B (+93.7%) · MOTIR, Nov 1

SOX (FRI OCT 30 CLOSE, CARRIED)
10,688.80 −7.20% · MU $884.74 (−5.30%) · SNDK $1,150.89 (−13.47%) · DDR5 16Gb spot $61.50 (TrendForce Oct 30, no weekend print)

LEAD STORY

TRADE · KOREA · DRAM AND NAND

Korea's Chip Exports Hit $56.4 Billion in October as DRAM Prices Keep Rising

Semiconductor shipments more than tripled from a year earlier and topped $50 billion for a second month, though they came in below September's record. The ministry's DRAM price series rose again; its NAND price was flat for a second month.

By the Memory Cycle Desk · Tel Aviv · ~09:30 IST Sunday (UTC+2) · Markets closed: prices are Friday Oct 30 closes · CONFIRMED unless marked

KEY NUMBERS · KOREA OCTOBER TRADE AND CONTRACT PRICES

KOREA OCTOBER EXPORTS

Total exports (y/y)	**$115.28B (+93.7%)**
Semiconductors (y/y)	**$56.44B (+259.4%)**
Chips, September record	**$60.3B**
Computers incl. SSDs (y/y)	**$5.85B (+496.6%)**
Chip-equipment imports (y/y)	**$2.52B (+49.2%)**
DDR5 16Gb / NAND 128Gb fixed (MOTIR)	**$50.0 (Sep $48.0) / $30.6 flat**

CONTRACT PRICES AND FRIDAY CLOSES (CARRIED)

DDR4 8Gb contract, Oct (DRAMeXchange)	**$27.50 (+5.77%)**
MLC NAND 128Gb contract, Oct	**$30.61 (flat)**
Micron / Sandisk	**$884.74 (−5.30%) / $1,150.89 (−13.47%)**
SK hynix / Samsung	**₩1,418,000 (−7.08%) / ₩225,000 (−3.02%)**
KOSPI / SOX	**5,730.74 (−3.48%) / −7.20%**
DDR5 16Gb spot (Oct 30)	**$61.50 (+0.27%)**

What this shows: Korea's memory exports are still running at record levels, and DRAM prices are still climbing, but NAND benchmark prices have stopped rising. Markets were shut for the weekend, so all share prices are Friday Oct 30 closes. Sources: Ministry of Trade, Industry and Resources (MOTIR), Yonhap, Asia Economy, Reuters; DRAMeXchange via BusinessKorea; prices from the Oct 31 edition (Yahoo Finance, TrendForce).

Korea's exports rose 93.7% from a year earlier to $115.28 billion in October, close to the +93.2% a Reuters poll expected, and the trade surplus was $42.5 billion (Yonhap, Reuters). Chips made up nearly half: $56.44 billion, up 259.4%, the second month above $50 billion but below September's record $60.3 billion (MOTIR, Asia Economy). Computer exports, driven by server SSDs, rose 496.6% to $5.85 billion.

The ministry's fixed-price series shows where the strength is. DDR5 16Gb rose to $50.0 from $48.0 in September, its fourth straight monthly rise from $40.0 in June. The 128Gb NAND price was $30.6 for a second month, after $28.8 in June (MOTIR).

Our call: unchanged overall. DRAM is still tightening; NAND price growth has stalled.

CYCLE SIGNAL: DRAM FIRM, NAND FLAT

PRICES · CONTRACT

DRAM Contract Price Sets a Record While NAND's 21-Month Climb Stalls

DRAMeXchange put October's DDR4 8Gb PC DRAM contract price at a record $27.50, up 5.77% from $26.00 in September. The 128Gb MLC NAND benchmark held at $30.61, ending 21 straight monthly rises (BusinessKorea, Osegi). TrendForce says MLC buyers are switching to relatively cheaper SLC or TLC parts, and sees MLC easing slightly in the fourth quarter, while SLC rose 5–10% in October. It kept its forecast of a 13–18% rise in fourth-quarter PC DRAM contract prices expects November prices slightly above October's, and sees Korean makers' PC DRAM output falling more than 20% next year.

CUSTOMERS · OPENAI

Altman Meets Samsung and SK Leaders as the Memory Crunch Deepens

OpenAI's Sam Altman met about 50 Samsung executives in Yongin on Saturday, building on the deal for Samsung to supply memory for the Stargate project (Bloomberg via The Straits Times, Seoul Economic Daily). SK Group chairman Chey Tae-won hosted him for lunch the same day, with SK hynix and SK Telecom executives present; local press expect HBM supply and AI data centers to have been discussed (Yonhap, Financial News). No new supply deal was announced. When the letters of intent were signed a year ago, OpenAI said the two makers were targeting up to 900,000 DRAM wafers a month.

SUPPLY · CHINA

CXMT Says Its Next-Generation 4F² DRAM Has Passed Sample Validation

China's CXMT said its sixth-generation DRAM platform, built on a $4F^2$ vertical-channel cell, has completed engineering-sample validation. Customer qualification comes next, and it plans to send DDR5 server-module (RDIMM) samples by the end of 2026 (Global Times, Yonhap). CXMT says it is first to reach this stage; Samsung aims to mass-produce $4F^2$ DRAM by 2028. No yields or volumes were given. Nine-month revenue rose 738.5% to 269.02 billion yuan.

FROM THE INBOX · SINCE OCT 31, 08:00 IST

NEW **Sandisk targets cut after the selloff.** Evercore $2,500 (from $2,800), BofA $2,000 (from $2,500), Melius $2,600 (from $3,600), Goldman $2,000 (from $2,200), Wells Fargo $1,300 (from $1,550). Broker notes via semis digest

NEW **Memory still the top pick.** Cantor: SOX −9% on the week, still +51% this year; ranks Memory over Compute over chip equipment, with Micron, Sandisk, Western Digital and Seagate among its top picks. Cantor weekly

NEW **Tool makers still see memory demand.** KLA's DRAM revenue rose 71% q/q in the September quarter, it guides +58% for December, and memory reaches 40% of its mix in 2027. Jefferies semis daily

Memory's share of cloud budgets. Morgan Stanley puts memory spending at 48% of cloud capex in 2026 and 53% in 2027; JPMorgan sees PC demand −12% in 2026 and −10% in 2027. Broker notes via semis digest

ON X · SINCE SAT ~08:00 · IST

@jukan05 · Oct 31 09:38
Altman made a visit to Korea to meet Samsung's top executives; local media say he also met SK hynix, a year after the trip that started the RAM price surge.
x.com/.../2116434574993666327

@jasonschips · Nov 1 00:03 UNCONFIRMED
Reports say OpenAI now seeks up to $20B in its funding round, down from a $30B target; the Samsung meeting announced no new chip volumes.
x.com/.../2116652326064677252

@ren_stocks · Nov 1 05:44 OPINION
Will be a net buyer of Micron, Sandisk and others over the coming months: "Buy in November, sell in June."
x.com/.../2116738074168500325

@Unclestocknotes · Oct 31 20:03
October DDR4 8Gb contract +5.77% to a record $27.50; MLC NAND flat at $30.61, ending 21 monthly rises. "Product-specific… does not establish a peak" in NAND.
x.com/.../2116592013684703287

@SemiconductorsX · Nov 1 04:40
SK hynix DRAM sales ₩19.1T → ₩57.6T → ₩78.4T (3Q25, 2Q26, 3Q26); NAND ₩5.0T → ₩21.4T → ₩25.7T.
x.com/.../2116721903478157639

CYCLE TRACKER · UNCHANGED: DRAM STILL TIGHTENING, NAND PRICES STALLED

GAUGE	TODAY VS OCT 31 (KPI WATCH LIST)	NUDGE
Contract ROC	DDR4 8Gb contract +5.77%, a record; MOTIR DDR5 16Gb +4.2% m/m; MLC NAND and MOTIR NAND flat	**DRAM up, NAND flat**
LTAs / lead times	No new deals; Altman met Samsung and SK leaders with no supply contract announced	**Long, steady**
Guide vs consensus	Korea exports +93.7% vs +93.2% poll; chips below September's record	**In line**
Capex / new supply	Korea chip-equipment imports +49.2%; CXMT 4F^2 passes sample validation, server samples by year-end	**Building**
Demand / de-spec	SSD exports +496.6%; MLC buyers moving to SLC or TLC; PC output cuts expected in 2027	**AI up, PCs down**

VERDICT VS PREVIOUS CALL (NO. 25, OCT 31)
Late upcycle; tight through 2027 and booked into 2028. Unchanged overall. DRAM is a touch firmer (record DDR4 contract, a fourth straight rise in Korea's DDR5 price, near-record chip exports); NAND is looser (MLC benchmark's 21-month run over, Korea's NAND price flat for a second month, echoing Kioxia's guide). Supply keeps building: tool imports up, CXMT's 4F^2 DRAM in sampling. Playbook: late-cycle amber for NAND, not a bust signal while DRAM contract gains still accelerate.

EVENTS CALENDAR · NOV 1–14 · ISRAEL TIME (IST, UTC+2) · US CASH OPEN NOW 16:30

Mon Nov 2	Apple FQ4 after the US close (call 00:00 Nov 3)	Demand
Tue Nov 3	US midterm elections · AMD (call 00:00 Nov 4) · Supermicro after the close	AI
Wed Nov 4	Qualcomm (call 23:45) · Arm (call 00:00 Nov 5)	Phones
Fri Nov 6	US payrolls 15:30 · Micron Taoyuan union talks resume (reported)	Macro

Mon Nov 9	Sandisk split record date (8-for-1; split-adjusted trading from Nov 20)	NAND
Tue Nov 10	TSMC October sales (07:30) · US CPI 15:30 · CoreWeave	AI

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Unconfirmed reports are labeled as such. Figures are only those cited from named sources. · Edition #26 · Nov 1, 2026